



HAUNTING SILENCE
A still from *The Last Rhododendron;* (inset) Yashasvi Juyal

the light of day. Before that happens, Juyal's calling card in the film industry, the eloquent and elegant 37-minute *The Last Rhododendron* is having its online premiere on MUBI on December 26. Uttarakhand-born Juyal shot the film in his home state. It won the Gender Sensitivity Award at the 2021 Dharamshala International Film Festival.

The film follows a young woman who leaves her single mother behind in a 'ghost village', which the best and the brightest are migrating out of, leaving behind resentful, gossiping villagers. Unusually quiet, poetic and hauntingly shot, *The Last Rhododendron* features Geeta Rana as Mamta, and Laxmi Devi Rana as Mamta's mother.

"Last year, while documenting Himalayan women weavers, I met Parvati, the last resident of her village," Juyal writes on the film. "Her daughter was preparing to leave for the city the next day, and Parvati's impending solitude embodied the complex interplay of sacrifice, resilience and heartbreak that defines migration in these hills."

A particularly humorous sequence depicts another mother-daughter pair bickering over Mamta leaving. The mother is adamant that Mamta has left to elope; the daughter resists. Inside, the evidently sensitive Juyal is a funny filmmaker.

The rhododendron is the state tree of Uttarakhand. The title pointedly suggests the unravelling of a state which is getting left behind. To Juyal, the tree is "a symbol of state pride frequently invoked by politicians" that "frames this story of abandonment and endurance". ■

—Devarsi Ghosh

FILM ▼

Breaking the **Binaries**

THE SHORT ***HOLY CURSE*** CHALLENGES GENDER BINARIES AND TRIES TO BROADEN THE SOUTH ASIAN LENS IN THE WEST



Helping Snigdha to achieve this is executive producer Lilly Singh, a popular Canadian YouTuber and actress better known by her former pseudonym 'Superwoman'. *Holy Curse* fits well with Lilly's own cause to advocate for gender equality. "What the film does is what I always try to do through my work: show that even when someone doesn't look like you or comes from a different culture, you can still connect with their emotions and their need to be seen and heard as their authentic self," she says. "The conversation we are trying to have is that we need more empathy and humanity."

> Snigdha aims to highlight how the **"misuse and misapplication of a ritual"** becomes especially harmful when the person imposing it feels that their "narrative is correct"

For Snigdha, who has worked on documentaries and was a cinematographer before turning to filmmaking, the short was a means to not just focus on a character who doesn't align with a gender binary but also to look at family dynamics in such a situation. More than critique, she seeks to show how the "misuse and misapplication of a ritual is problematic", especially when the person imposing it feels that their "narrative is correct".

Regardless of whether *Holy Curse* makes the Oscar shortlist, Lilly calls the short the work she's "most proud" of. That's also because she sees in it what she loves: make commentary through comedy and broaden the South Asian cultural lens of Hollywood. "I know people here view Indians and all South Asians a certain way. Only reference they have is Bollywood," says Lilly. "I want the world to see the diversity and the different storytellers, like Snigdha, who create meaningful and impactful work." ■

— Suhani Singh